

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Pentecost 9
Another Kind of Freedom ~ Radical Love
2 August 2026

Preaching: ML

Worship Leading: LVF & Janette Tovar

David's & Laurel's Last Sunday | Strips of paper in programs for prayers

Organ Prelude-Concert

Ave Maria op. 106 no. 2 – Sigfrid Karg-Elert

Fantasia super *Jesu meine Freude* BWV 713 – J. S. Bach

Sonata no. 1 in F minor – Felix Mendelssohn

1. Allegro moderato e serio
2. Adagio
3. Andante recitativo
4. Allegro assai veloce

Dr. Abraham Ross, *Guest Organist*

Chiming of the Hour

[Laura and Janette center chancel]

Welcome

LVF

Words of Gathering

JT & LVF

JT: If we boil down the purpose of all of our living.
If we follow the thread of all our questions.
If we uncover what is beneath all this grief and discovery:

*We find love, love, love,
The very heartbeat of God.*

LVF: Love, sturdy and steadfast.

Love, heartbreaking and heart-opening.

JT: Love, as in, we belong to each other.

Love, as in, we will let sorrow turn us towards compassion.

LVF: Love, as in, we will let compassion guide us
towards wise action.

Love, as in, God is within each living thing.

JT: Love as in, God moves between us.

*Love, as in, God is the possibility
that stretches before us.*

LVF: This morning, we give thanks for love
in all its dimensions, as we open our hearts,
our minds, and our bodies
in this time set apart.

[adpt/enfleshed]

JT: *Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering.*

***Hymn of Gathering** **Love Now Ascending - NICAEA.pdf**

Holy, holy, holy, love now ascending
Early in the morning our song shall rise to you.
Holy, holy, holy, joy that has no ending
Giving, forgiving, breathing life anew.

Holy, holy, holy, love without a limit
Care that binds creation in sacred unity,
Holy, holy, holy, birthing every minute,
Christ, Love's revealer, sets our spirits free.

Holy, holy, holy, infinite compassion,
Makes a place for every soul in God's eternal reign,
Holy, holy, holy, truth beyond religion,
Love that endures should nothing else remain.

Holy, holy, holy, raise your voice in singing,
Join the cosmic chorus in praise of Love divine,
Holy, holy, holy, God beyond all naming,
Echoes our song in harmony sublime.

-[JBurklo]

[Laura center chancel]

***Prayer of Awareness**

LVF

God of fresh starts, of new beginnings,
of renewal and restoration.
We awake to your grace,
embraced by love unconditional.

With each new morning you birth possibilities
in us and around us.
We are surrounded by Sacred potential
and we know deep in our hearts,
there are so many ways to love.

May we rise to this day's call;
to listen for the aches,

to give voice to the beauty,
to be companions to justice,
and to drink from the deep well of joy,
both now and in all the days to come.

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us -

Amen and Amen!

[adpt/m.jadekaiser]

[All turn towards choir]

***Introit**

“Love is love is love”
Cathedral Choir

Abbie Betinis

[Janette to lectern]

***The Lord’s Prayer**

JT

Let us now join our voices in this Lord’s Prayer...

*Weaver of Life, Ancient and Unfolding,
How sacred is your Presence!
We lean on your guidance.
We seek your love.
We open to your transformation.
Provide us bread in body and spirit
to sustain us in faith and solidarity.
Companion us with grace
as we seek to live lives of forgiveness and compassion,
repair and accountability.
We remember those who have supported us
as we seek to support others
in all the mess and glory of this human journey.
Guard our minds and hearts from the temptation of domination
and turn our loyalty away from the systems of evil.
For the whole cosmos hums with your wisdom.
Everything that lives, returns to your care.
Our thanks and honor to you,
Gracious Web of Existence,
Our Source and our Home.
Amen and Amen.*

[enfleshed]

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Laura to center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace**

LVF

Though the mystery of God remains beyond grasp,
the Spirit gifts us with glimpses of justice,
with touches of love,
and with whispers of truth.

Always and everywhere,
the Wisdom of God is being revealed,
that we might live and love differently together,
free from the ways that destroy.
On this day, may we recognize the Holy Mystery that surrounds us
and reveals the ways of collective liberation - and beauty.

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are now invited to share this greeting with those near you.

Please be seated

[Janette to lectern]

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition *from the Gospel of Luke* **JT**

Speaking to a great number of disciples and a large crowd of people from all over the region,
Jesus shared these words of wisdom, written in the Gospel of Luke, chapter 6...

“To you who hear me, I say: love your enemies. Do good to those who hate you,
bless those who curse you, and pray for those who mistreat you.
When they slap you on one cheek, turn and give them the other; when they take your coat, let
them have your shirt as well. Give to all who beg from you. When someone takes what is yours,
don’t demand it back.

“Do to others what you would have them do to you. If you love those who love you, what credit
does that do you? Even those who choose to harm others, love those who love them. If you do
good only to those who do good to you, what credit does that do you? Even those who choose to
harm others do as much.

“If you lend to those you expect to repay you, what credit does that do you? Even those who
choose to harm others lend to others expecting to be repaid in full. Love your enemies and do

good to them. Lend without expecting repayment, and your reward will be great. You'll rightly be called children of the most high, since God is good even to the ungrateful and the wicked.

“Be compassionate, as your loving God is compassionate. Don't judge, and you won't be judged. Don't condemn, and you won't be condemned. Pardon, and you'll be pardoned. Give, and it will be given to you: a full measure—packed down, shaken together and running over—will be poured into your lap. For the amount you measure out is the amount you'll be given back.”

This is the Gospel of Radical Love.
Thanks be to God!

[Abe short transition Laura center chancel]

Prayers with the People

LVF

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

As we come to this time of silence and prayer, we are invited once again to remember that we are not alone. Whether we come from near or far, we are wrapped in a love that has the power to turn enemies into friends and friends into family.

As we breathe in the peace that surrounds us in this space we make holy by our presence together, we pray that the Divine will remind us we are all the people who carry the image of God within us, around us, and among us.

As we share these moments of silence, we are invited to write the prayers of our hearts for our lives and the life of our world on the slips of paper in our programs. If you are online, please share your prayers by emailing prayers@fccla.org.

Then, as the music begins, we are invited to come forward to share our prayers here in the bowl, and to light candles signifying our prayers, for ourselves, those we love and hold dear - and for the life of the world.

Let us now be in silence, together.

Silence

[Abe transition out of silence as people come forward to offer prayers and light candles]

[Laura center chancel when all are seated]

Prayer of Our Hearts

Holy One, deep within our being, we give thanks for life and for the love that makes us whole.

No matter where we go, you are with us.

If we wander from love's way out of fear or in pursuit of power,

you come to find us.

If we are turned away from places we once called home,
you walk with us on the road to freedom.

If we desire to create places of belonging
that are just and restorative,
you empower us with all we need.

If we go looking for what is missing in us,
you meet us in the searching,
and lead us on the paths of restoration.

You help us, Holy One, to not grow weary in doing good,
in telling the truth, in loving one another,
in practicing and pursuing what is just,
and in finding renewal in the beauty and delight
that persists around us.

Holy One, help us to realize you will never stop reminding us
that always and forever, we are your beloved children,
no matter where we go.

In these precious moments, we give thanks for the roads we have traveled together,
and we give thanks for all that is before us.
Amen and Amen.

[Abe transition for choir]

Meditation Music

“You Are Music” from *Symphony For Voices 3: Mycelial*. David Harris
Laude

“You are music...you are the universe greeting itself for a brief moment.” ~Dr. Roger Penrose

“Introit and Kyrie” from *Requiem in D Minor* W.A. Mozart
Cathedral Choir

“Let perpetual light shine on us. We sing to the God of love, the love that marks our beginning
and our ending. God have mercy, Christ have mercy.”

“Beati Quorum Via” Charles Villiers Stanford
Laude
“Blessed are they who walk with God, whose way is steadfast love.”

[Abe transition Michael to pulpit, choir to seats]

[Abe transition Janette to lectern]

Invitation to Generosity

JT

‘Love,’ writes Carter Heyward, ‘is a conversion to humanity - a willingness to participate with others in the healing of a broken world and broken lives.

Love is the choice to experience life as a member of the human family, a partner in the dance of life, rather than as an alien in the world or as a deity above the world, aloof and apart from human flesh.’

Giving of our time, our talents, and our money is one way we can enter the dance of life, in this our time and place. Each week we are invited you to give from your resources for the work we are doing together. This week, you will find a QR Code in program if you are here in person, or on your screen if you are online. This code will direct funds to our Food@First program which is making such a difference in so many lives.

Through your gifts, we can continue providing need food resources to our neighbors and friends.

FOOD AT FIRST QR Code

Offertory Anthem “Ah, Non Credea, Ah! Non Giunge”

Vincenzo Bellini

Laurel Irene and Dr. Abraham Ross

“I didn’t believe that love could fade so quickly. Perhaps my tears can revive you. Ah! Human thought can’t manage to grasp the happiness I feel. I can barely believe my own senses. Love is revived! Let us always unite in a single hope. From this place that we live, we shall build a heaven of love.”

[All turn towards altar]

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator’s praise arise!

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[Janette to lectern toward end of doxology]

***Offering Prayer**

JT

God of Grace and Love, remind us as we leave this time together,
that you made us in your image

and filled us with your Spirit of Love.

As we offer all our gifts and talents, O God,
give us the vision to embody your wildly inclusive love,
so that by our words and our actions,
we may dismantle the walls of division
and co-create our lives with your grace and love,
on this day and on all the days to come.

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

[Laura & Michael center chancel]

Life at First Church

ML & LVF

LVF: Next week, our summer series, *Another Kind of Freedom*, continues with the theme, *Kin-dom Economics*. We're also excited to welcome back Dr. Jaebon Hwang as our guest organist. Would you please join me in thanking Dr. Abraham Ross, our guest organist the past two Sundays.

ML: Summer Clothing Drive is ongoing- bring new or gently used summer clothing items to the security booth anytime! We'll share those with our neighbors as part of Food@First on Sunday, Aug. 16. We give thanks for that team serving today, and for our Gardens team that harvested 500 bundles of fresh herbs and vegetables this morning.

LVF: Next Sunday, Aug. 9, our LGBTQ+ group here is hosting another Book Launch following the service in Shatto Chapel. And our Community Collaborative is hosting a Summer Picnic in the Amanda Scott Gardens on Saturday, Aug. 29th!

ML, LVF, and Jason Lambert: Recognizing David and Laurel

LVF: Word about Dr. Fahad Siadat and Dr. Ianthe Marini serving as co-interim directors.

Words of Blessing

ML

The world now is too dangerous
and too beautiful for anything but love.

May your eyes be so blessed you see God in everyone.
Your ears, so you hear the cry of the poor.

May your hands be so blessed
that everything you touch is a sacrament.
Your lips, so you are speaking nothing but the truth in love.

May your feet be so blessed you run
to those who need you.

And may your heart be so opened,
so set on fire, that your love,
your love, changes everything.

[A Black Rock Prayerbook]

May it forever be so.
May it forever be so for all of us!

Choral Response

“I Remember, I Believe”
Cathedral Choir

Bernice Johnson Reagon

*Hymn for the Journey

God Whose Love is Always Stronger

HYFRYDOL

 **3.13 OW FINAL.pdf**

God whose love is always stronger than our weakness, pride and fear,
In your world, we pray and wonder how to be more faithful here.
Hate too often grows inside us; Fear rules what the nations do.
So we pray, when life divides us: Give us love, God! Make us new!

Love is patient, kind and caring. Never arrogant or rude,
Never boastful, all things bearing; Love rejoices in the truth.
When we're caught up in believing we will never live in peace,
Show us Jesus' way of living; May our strength in you increase.

May our faith in you be nourished; May all people hear your call.
May our lives be filled with courage as we speak your grace for all.
Now emboldened by your Spirit who has given us new birth,
Give us love, that we may share it till your love renews the earth.
[adapt/CarolynWinfreyGillette]

[Laura center chancel]

Postlude

Fugue in G major K. 574 – W. A. Mozart

Dr. Abraham Ross, *Guest Organist*

Inside The Music

Reflecting on almost a decade here at FCCLA, I feel overwhelmed by the magnitude of love and connection I've shared in community with you all. There aren't words for what this experience has meant to me, and we are going to miss you all deeply. The music today is several pieces that I really wanted to sing. They connect around a broader, universal integration of love and being.

Some are more obvious, like Abbie Betinis' "Love Is Love Is Love" that she wrote for simple group singing, though the message is anything but simple in our day and age. The famous "Ah, Non Credea, Ah! Non Giunge" from Bellini's "La Sonnambula" is a monster anthem to love. The opera's finale, it brings everyone together around a belief that love is the central architect of life, and we can hope to love in perpetuity. I wrote "Symphony For Voices 3: Mycelial" as a long-form improvisation. We'll do the last part of it today, which was inspired by the physicist Roger Penrose. I heard him speak passionately about our connection to the universe, ergo, all things. I amended his quote a little for the music. In the actual quote he says: "You are music. . . You are the universe experiencing itself for a brief moment before dissolving back into the eternal field structure." Every time I think about this I'm moved. The world around us, everything we know and understand, are expressions of the same eternal field structure. For whatever reason we come into being and then we return to that oneness. That, to me, is the essence of love, and it makes me want to love deeply in order to remain close to the source for the time that I am aware of my place in the universe. I feel like Mozart was experiencing a similar reflection as he wrote his final piece, the "Requiem in D Minor." The opening is so tender, and even the double fugue in the "Kyrie" rings with depths of passion and promise. Although he set the text of the death mass for which he was commissioned, the music explodes with the beauties of life and love. It rattles through us reminding us to awaken into the energy of this moment. He's calling to us still to live and love and be in concert with each other. The simple, elegant beauty of Stanford's "Beati quorum via" speaks for itself as an expression of commitment to love as a way of life. It always makes me feel expanded and connected to others. And I had to program something by Bernice Johnson Reagon. She is one of the composers whose capacity to communicate deep truths has so consistently marked my time here with you all. I love hearing and singing her music. In the last verse of "I Remember, I Believe" that we'll sing she resonates with these other composers by saying "My God called to me in the morning due, the power of the universe knows my name. Gave me a song to sing and sent me on my way, I raise my voice for justice, and I believe." The whole song has a careful balance around knowing and unknowing. In the song, she releases that which she can't fathom into places that won't weigh us down as she picks up the song that she's been given and sings it for all to hear. That's a promise to live by, and one that FCCLA has been leaning into more and more over the last decade. I'll enjoy watching the ways that you all continue to deepen into the strengths of this community as it leads the way into the future of Los Angeles and the world, even as it brings you all together in love.